First Day of Winter

By Sam Smiley

INTRODUCTION

The first day of winter, plants begin to die. But are plants the only thing affected by the cold stillness that this season ushers in? As relationships grow, people change, and we begin to realize that some were never truly alive to begin with. What lives, and what dies on the "First Day of Winter" by Sam Smiley.

(LEAH walks into the field carrying a spade and an antique wooden box. She gently sets the wooden box on the earth, shoves the spade into the ground, and lifts out dirt. Then with head bowed she kneels, picks up the box, and presses it against her chest. ANDREW hurries into view and stops momentarily at the edge of the field.)

ANDREW: Leah. *(No reply)* Leah, what are you doing out here? *(She shakes her head.)* What? I can't hear you in the wind.

LEAH: I didn't say anything.

ANDREW: It's winter. *(Looks around.)* You'll freeze to death out here in the open.

LEAH: No, I won't.

ANDREW: It's five o'clock in the morning! What's going on? I mean, what are you doing out here with a shovel?

LEAH: It's a spade.

ANDREW: All right, a spade. And what're you holding?

LEAH: A box.

ANDREW: I can see that. What's inside?

LEAH: Andy, you know how I hate questions. That's all I get these days, questions... from everyone - parents, friends, teachers, and especially from

ANDREW: Especially from me. Right? *(Sarcastic)* Well, I'm sorry.

LEAH: It would help a lot if you would just please go away. *(Puts her forehead against the box.)*

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ANDREW: C'mon, Leah. Don't do that. Don't cry. Darlin', get up off that cold ground and talk to me. *(She collects herself)*

LEAH: I have nothing more to say.

ANDREW: We should get out of this wind. I'm freezing.

LEAH: Button your coat.

ANDREW: Yeah. See? Without you, I'm practically helpless. *(He buttons his coat.)*

LEAH: Helpless as a shark.

ANDREW: That's not very nice.

LEAH: I'm tired of being nice. Tired of school, tired of this town, and I am deathly tired of

ANDREW: Me?

LEAH: No, of hiding. I want to get on with my life.

ANDREW: Then let's go somewhere warm and talk it out.

LEAH: I said everything last night.

ANDREW: And you think I believed any of it?

LEAH: Andrew, don't make it so difficult, for both of us.

ANDREW: I won't ... if you explain where you've been all night. *(She bows over the wooden box.)* You know, I've always thought that maroon scarf looks like blood running down your neck. Where were you?

LEAH: I spent the night helping a friend.

ANDREW: Leah, I checked with all your friends - Bonnie, Gina, Max, Darlene - everyone. I went to all your favorite places. I even called Jonathan.

LEAH: You didn't! *(She rises.)* You called Jonathan? I haven't spoken to him for a year and a half.

ANDREW: He told me that. And I also talked to Professor Carlson.

LEAH: Andy!

ANDREW: I thought you might have some kind of rehearsal.

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LEAH: You know perfectly well my final performance was last weekend. I'm done. No more rehearsals or performances. None! I told you that. My degree is finished.

ANDREW: Yeah, Carlson reminded me. Said he hadn't seen you since last Saturday night.

LEAH: Sometimes I could kill you.

ANDREW: Thanks. You know, I don't think Carlson likes me. Every time I'm around him, he watches you like a vulture. I think he's jealous. Has he ever come on to you?

LEAH: *(Indignant)* Professor Carlson?

ANDREW: OK, look, I'm just tired and upset ... and I'm freezing my tail off. Let's get out of this wind.

LEAH: Go away, Andy. I have something important to do.

ANDREW: Leah, I have been searching for you all night, the whole lousy night! I didn't even go home. See, I'm still wearing the same clothes. *(LEAH picks up the spade.)* What are you doing? Listen to me a minute, OK? Listen! *(She faces him again.)* Ever since you walked out of that restaurant ... I mean I sat there for all of a minute, finished my Coke, and went after you. But by the time I got outside, you were gone. Poof! Into the night. I looked everywhere - nothing! I called your place about fifty times, checked with your friends, and ... darlin', you better get off that ground before you catch your death.

LEAH: Don't worry about me.

ANDREW: I am worried out of my mind about you. Leah, I cannot - I know it sounds melodramatic - I cannot live without you. When we're apart, I get this weird sensation. *(Touches his chest.)* Like there's a steel band clamped around my chest, squeezing the breath out of me. I can't let you go. Now, tell me where you were!

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LEAH: Andrew, I spent last night with my cat Samantha.

ANDREW: Oh, yeah sure! Man, my hands are cold.

LEAH: Here, take my mittens. *(She starts to remove them, but he prevents her by grabbing her hands.)*

ANDREW: No, Leah! I want you to have the mittens, all the clothes you want, career, house, money, fame, fortune, travel... everything your heart desires, because, Leah, I love you. *(He draws her close.)*

LEAH: You've never said that before, Andy.

ANDREW: Haven't I?

LEAH: In all the time we've spent together, not once.

ANDREW: Well, I do. Very much. *(Kisses her.)* And you love me, too, don't you? *(He lifts her off the ground.)*

LEAH: I haven't been able to help myself.

ANDREW: That's my girl. *(Sets her down.)*

LEAH: I'm touched that you spent the night looking for me.

ANDREW: Yeah, well I did.

LEAH: It shows you honestly care.

ANDREW: I was out of my mind. For all I knew, some skinheads grabbed you in the parking lot and shoved you in a van or something.

LEAH: Not knowing is always worse than reality. *(He takes her face in his hands.)*

ANDREW: Leah, you are so beautiful. *(Lightly kisses her.)* But your lips are ice. Let's get out of this wind.

LEAH: No, I have to finish. *(She gestures at the hole.)*

ANDREW: What are you doing?

LEAH: Digging.

ANDREW: Oh, yeah - for gold? *(Laughs a little.)*

LEAH: No.

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ANDREW: Well, it's the wrong time of year for a garden.

LEAH: It's a grave. *(That stops him.)*

ANDREW: You got to be kidding. *(Again LEAH kneels beside the box.)* Leah, what the hell have you got in there? *(She shakes her head.)* I don't believe it! You've got to be kidding. Don't tell me you... *(He gets down on one knee and puts an arm around her shoulders.)* Look at me, Leah. Darlin', look at me! *(He turns her face toward him.)* You never said anything. You never told me.

LEAH: I know. *(She pulls away.)*

ANDREW: You should have.

LEAH: It doesn't matter now.

ANDREW: Of course it matters! *(Loud)* It matters!

LEAH: Don't yell at me, Andy.

ANDREW: I'm not. I am simply saying you should have told me. *(Beat)* So anyway it's all over now, right?

LEAH: Yes, it is past.

ANDREW: *(Sudden thought)* Leah, you didn't do it yourself! You should've gone to a hospital, right?

LEAH: I did.

ANDREW: Oh. In a hospital- and you're all right?

LEAH: I'm fine.

ANDREW: Now, wait a minute. When did all this happen? Not last night! Is that where you were, in a hospital?

LEAH: No. It happened long before last night. Three weeks ago to be exact. Remember when I told you I had a stomach virus?

ANDREW: *(Nods.)* But I still don't understand. *(Soft)* What've you got in the box?

LEAH: Please, Andrew.

ANDREW: Now wait, I want to know. What's in the box?

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LEAH: I'll tell you. But first, you explain how you found me.

ANDREW: What do you mean?

LEAH: How did you know to come out here?

ANDREW: Simple. I went up the steps over there in back of the house. *(Points.)* I knocked on your apartment door, and no one answered. So I turned on the landing and looked around. From that angle up there I could see a dark figure walking into this field. I mean, you're a dancer, and I'd know you anywhere just from the way you move.

LEAH: What phone did you use last night to call my friends?

ANDREW: The one in my office.

LEAH: You drove clear down to your office?

ANDREW: Sure. Better than spending a fortune in quarters.

LEAH: Why didn't you bother to drive out here last night?

ANDREW: I called your apartment, and no one answered.

LEAH: Have you ever been at home but avoided the phone?

ANDREW: You were there?

LEAH: Andy, it is very odd that you searched for me eight and a half hours without ever coming by to look in my apartment. I think you're lying ... again.

ANDREW: Darlin', I swear

LEAH: You're awfully good at it. You didn't search for me all night, did you? You went home to her. Just like always. *(ANDREW presses his lips together and gazes into the distance. Pause)* It's over, Andy. Today's the first day of winter. It's a natural time to let it die. *(LEAH picks up the spade and digs out more dirt.)*

ANDREW: Let it die? No, Leah, you want to kill it and bury it. Right? *(She continues digging.)* I want to know what's in the box. *(She goes on.)* Come on! Show me! *(He grabs the spade away from her. LEAH picks up the wooden box. sets it*

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on the pile of dirt from the grave. and kneels beside it.)

LEAH: I tacked down the lid. Do you have a pocket knife?

ANDREW: Me? No.

LEAH: I can't get it off.

ANDREW: Here, try one of my keys. My fingers are frozen stiff. *(He pulls a ring of keys from his pocket and hands them to her.)*

LEAH: Andrew, I don't want to show you this.

ANDREW: Show me, Leah! You better show me, or... *(Momentarily, his frustrations come to focus. and he lifts the spade as though he might hit her in back of the head. But of course he cannot. He lowers the Spade and lets it slide out of his hands)* Never mind. I don't want to see anything.

LEAH: No, I want you to. *(She pries off the lid, lifts the box toward him with both hands like an offering. He looks inside)*

ANDREW: I don't believe it. *(Tries to laugh.)* It's a kitten.

LEAH: What did you expect? Look again.

ANDREW: One little black... no, two black kittens.

LEAH: Look closer.

ANDREW: One black kitten ... with two heads. *(Repulsed, he looks away)* Oh, man, I am freezing to death.

LEAH: Andrew, last night I helped my cat Samantha give birth to a litter. This little one amazed us both. A totally black, stillborn kitten with two perfect heads.

ANDREW: It's just a freak. Call a newspaper or the museum. *(LEAH replaces the lid on the box.)*

LEAH: I thought of that, but I decided it was better to bring it out here, into the open, and return it to the earth ... maybe with a prayer.

ANDREW: Then hurry up and do it so we can go to your apartment and wrap ourselves

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around each other and get warm.

LEAH: Can't you understand? Whatever joy we shared, it's ...

ANDREW: ... only temporary, right? Leah, think of all the great times we've had - the hiking, the skiing, the cabin in the woods. You want to end it? I have promised and promised you that one of these days we'll go away together!

LEAH: Y ou don't believe that and neither do I and anyway it's too late. It was too late when I went to the hospital.

ANDREW: Well, I'll tell you one thing - I can't stay out here another minute. I am freezing to death. *(Beat)* Maybe you're right. Maybe it's time for me to just walk away.

LEAH: Good-bye, Andrew.

ANDREW: Why in the name of... why bury a freak kitten?

LEAH: Because it was real, because life is so inventive, because I wonder what other strange seeds lie hidden in some secret womb. I only want to cover it peacefully with dark soil ... and a blanket of dried weeds. *(ANDREW nods and walks away. LEAH sets the little box into its grave.)*

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